with the Kachin Independence Organisation (KIO) and its armed wing, the Kachin Independence Army (KIA). The KIO/A are one of the larger, better organized and more formidable of the non-state armed groups, with a presence spread across a significant part of Kachin and northern Shan States, and while the other ceasefire deals were unwritten 'gentlemen's agreements', the Kachin ceasefire was the only one with a signed document (although the signed document was kept secret for a decade). For most of its seventeen years, the Kachin ceasefire also appeared among the most stable and led to a wealth of state-led, civil society and commercial development activity, including the rapid expansion of resource extraction.

Since the return to armed conflict by the KIO/A in June 2011, and their recalcitrant stance in national ceasefire negotiations, analysis has begun to emphasize the growing role of resource exploitation, and it has been tempting to characterize this as a resource-driven conflict. Certainly, almost all violent clashes between the Tatmadaw and the KIA since 2011 have centred around the control of resources and resource trade corridors, suggesting it is pertinent to once again re-examine the causes and characteristics of the Kachin conflict.

This chapter presents analysis of field research conducted by the authors in late 2014, using responses of key informants to discuss the key theoretical ideas employed in most discussions of this conflict: namely, 'ethnicity', 'identity', 'territory', and 'resources'. It seeks to make sense of the contemporary Kachin conflict through critical analysis of the expressions of proximal and root causes given by key actors against history and the literature, to illuminate the framing and drivers of the conflict and derive implications for achieving sustainable peace in the upcoming political dialogue. The field research involved key informant interviews with senior state officials, representatives from the non-state armed and civil groups, negotiators and advisors to the peace process, and key personnel from CSOs, multilateral agencies, donors, and INGOs.

There has been a long academic debate about the causes of conflict, particularly between 'grievance' and 'greed' theories. 'Ethnic' conflict is almost always perceived as a form of 'grievance' (for example, Geertz 1973; Horowitz 1985; Huntington 1996). Since Collier and Hoeffler (1998, 2002), debate about the causes of conflict have been focused mainly between 'grievance' and 'greed' theories. Rejection of ethnic-based 'grievance' as a driver of conflict has therefore often been used to categorize conflict as driven by 'greed', such as contestation over resource control and elite